8 ways a CRM sync fails without telling you

A sync can run green for months while quietly sending bad data. These are the patterns I look for first, and how to check each one in about ten minutes.

1 A placeholder left in a live field

LOOKS LIKE A test value typed in while building (a sample headcount, a fixed date) never got swapped for the real field.

WHY IT HIDES Nothing errors. Every record just gets the same value.

CHECK Pull 20 recent records. Is any field identical on all of them?

2 A test ID hardcoded in a live step

LOOKS LIKE One step uses a literal record ID instead of a mapped value, so it keeps processing the same record.

WHY IT HIDES The step succeeds every time, just on the wrong data.

CHECK Open every step. Any value that is not a mapped field is a suspect.

3 A match key saved only when a record is created

LOOKS LIKE The source ID is written on create but not on update, so records that already existed never get it.

WHY IT HIDES Later lookups quietly miss those records and create a duplicate or an orphan.

CHECK Count the records that are missing the key. It should be zero.

4 Searching on a blank value

LOOKS LIKE A contact with no email gets searched by email anyway.

WHY IT HIDES A blank search can return nothing, or the wrong record, and neither raises an error.

CHECK Put a "does the value exist?" guard in front of every search, and log what it skips.

5 Overlapping match conditions

LOOKS LIKE An OR condition that already covers a narrower one, so the narrow rule does nothing and the broad one over-matches.

WHY IT HIDES It works for most names, then merges two different customers that share a long prefix.

CHECK Test with two test records that share the first 40 characters of their name.

6 Updates that overwrite good data

LOOKS LIKE An update step sends blank or fixed text to a field that already has a real value.

WHY IT HIDES The record saves fine. The old value is just gone.

CHECK Run an update on a record that already has data. Compare the field before and after.

7 Defaults that invent data

LOOKS LIKE A missing date becomes today, a missing owner becomes a catch-all user.

WHY IT HIDES The default keeps the sync alive, but reports built on that field are now wrong.

CHECK List every default. For each one, ask which report reads that field.

8 Leftovers: debug switches and dead outputs

LOOKS LIKE Debug logging still on in production, or a flag calculated from the wrong variable that nothing reads yet.

WHY IT HIDES Noisy logs bury real errors. A dead flag is harmless until someone starts relying on it.

CHECK Search for debug switches. For every output, find what reads it.

Want this run on your sync? I can audit it against live data, list every issue with how serious it is, and fix the ones that matter. Message me on Upwork with what you're connecting and what you've noticed.

Patterns drawn from auditing multi-stage CRM integrations. Examples are generic. No company or customer data.